

Hindi Diwas 2026



Source: IE

Why in News?

Hindi Diwas was observed on 14 th September , marking the historic decision of the **Constituent Assembly on 14 th September 1949** , to adopt the **Munshi-Ayyangar formula** for resolving India's contentious language question.

- The occasion brings renewed attention to the **language debate in the Constituent Assembly** and how India balanced the promotion of Hindi with the linguistic diversity of the country.

What was the Language Debate in the Constituent Assembly?

- **The Contentious Issue:** At the time of Independence, India was highly multilingual. The primary debate was whether English (the language of colonial administration spoken by less than 1% of Indians) should be replaced by an indigenous language, and which language should hold official status at the Centre.
- **The Hindi Protagonists:** Representatives from Hindi-speaking areas (such as R.V. Dhulekar and Seth Govind Das) aggressively advocated for Hindi to become the sole "**national language**".
 - They argued that a multilingual society was incompatible with national unity and demanded the immediate replacement of English.
- **The Non-Hindi Representatives:** Members from non-Hindi-speaking regions (especially the South) strongly rejected linguistic uniformity.
 - Leaders like Shri Shankarrao Deo advocated for "**unity in diversity**," warning against the cultural erasure and imposition of Hindi on linguistic minorities.
- **The Moderates:** Leaders like **Jawaharlal Nehru** and **Maulana Abul Kalam Azad** preferred **Hindustani** (a blend of Hindi and Urdu championed by Mahatma Gandhi) or advocated for a gradual, organic development of the official language, noting Hindi's then-limited technical and administrative vocabulary.

Munshi-Ayyangar Formula

- After three years of deadlocked and heated debates, a middle path was crafted by Drafting Committee members **K.M. Munshi** and **N. Gopalaswami Ayyangar** .

- **Key Provisions of the Compromise :**

- **Official, Not National:** The formula carefully **avoided designating Hindi as India's "national language."** Instead, it declared **Hindi in the Devanagari script as the "official language" of the Union government** .
- **Continuation of English:** To assure non-Hindi states, English was permitted to continue alongside Hindi as an associate official language for a transition period of **15 years** (until 1965) to ensure a smooth administrative transition.
 - Later, when the 15-year sunset clause expired in 1965, violent anti-Hindi agitations erupted across non-Hindi-speaking states, especially Tamil Nadu. In response, Parliament enacted the **Official Languages Act, 1963** , ensuring that **English would continue indefinitely** alongside Hindi for Union administration and inter-state communication.
- **Numerals:** The international form of Hindu-Arabic numerals was adopted for official Union purposes, balancing the demands of those who wanted Devanagari numerals.
- **Regional Languages:** States were granted the freedom to choose any regional language (or English) for their internal administration.
- **Constitutional Provisions:** The Munshi-Ayyangar formula was incorporated into Part XVII of the Constitution (Articles 343 to 351).
 - **Article 343:** Declares Hindi in Devanagari script as the official language of the Union.
 - **Article 348:** Mandates that all proceedings in the Supreme Court and High Courts, as well as authoritative texts of legislation, shall be in English.
 - Under Article 348(2), a State Governor, with the prior consent of the President, can authorize the use of **Hindi or the State's official language in High Court proceedings**.
 - **Article 350A:** Directs states to provide facilities for instruction in the mother tongue at the primary stage of education.
 - **Article 351:** Issues a directive for the Union to promote the spread and development of the Hindi language.
 - **Eighth Schedule:** The Constitution initially recognized 14 major regional languages under the Eighth Schedule to ensure their protection and development. Through subsequent constitutional amendments, this list has been expanded to **22 languages, which includes Hindi as one of the original 14**.
 - Notably, English is not included in the Eighth Schedule. English continues as an associate official language through the Official Languages Act, 1963.

Hindi Diwas 2026

- **The 6th All India Official Language Conference:** Held alongside Hindi Diwas 2026 in Navi Mumbai, Maharashtra.
 - It promotes Hindi as a functional link language while fostering synergy and co-existence with other scheduled Indian regional languages.
- **Official Language Awards (2025-26):**
 - **Rajbhasha Kirti Puraskar:** It is the highest award given by the Department of Official Language (Ministry of Home Affairs) to honor ministries, departments, public sector undertakings (PSUs), and banks for their outstanding implementation, compliance, and correspondence in Hindi.
 - **Key Winners (2025-26):**
 - **Ministry of Defence (MoD):** Secured the **First Prize** in the category of ministries and departments with **more than 300 personnel** .
 - **Department of Financial Services (DFS):** Won the **First Prize** in the category of ministries and departments with **fewer than 300 personnel** . The award recognized its effective implementation, wider use, and innovative promotion of Hindi in official work.
 - **Rajbhasha Utkrishtata Sammaan (Special Recognition):** As per the guidelines of the Department of Official Language, any ministry or department that wins the first prize for two consecutive years becomes ineligible for the standard Rajbhasha Kirti Puraskar in the third year.
 - The **Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances (DARPG)** won the Rajbhasha Kirti Puraskar (First Prize) in 2023-24 and 2024-25, and received the special Rajbhasha Utkrishtata Sammaan for its sustained excellence in promoting Hindi in official work.
 - **Rajbhasha Gaurav Puraskar:** Recognizes individual authors and government employees for writing original books, literature, and outstanding articles in Hindi.

Note: Hindi Diwas is distinct from **World Hindi Day (Vishwa Hindi Diwas)** , which is observed on **10 th January** to commemorate the **First World Hindi Conference held in Nagpur in 1975** and promote Hindi internationally.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. Is Hindi the national language of India?

No. The Constitution does not designate any language as India's **national language**. Article 343 provides for **Hindi in Devanagari script as the official language of the Union**.

2. What was the Munshi-Ayyangar formula?

It was a Constituent Assembly compromise that made **Hindi the Union's official language**, while permitting the continued use of **English for an initial transitional period** and accommodating linguistic diversity.

3. Why did English continue after the 15-year constitutional transition period?

The **Official Languages Act, 1963**, as subsequently amended, enabled English to continue alongside Hindi for Union official purposes, addressing concerns of non-Hindi-speaking states.

4. What does Article 351 of the Constitution provide?

Article 351 places a **directive on the Union to promote the spread and development of Hindi**, while drawing upon Hindustani and other Indian languages for its enrichment.

5. How does the Constitution protect India's linguistic diversity?

It provides safeguards through **regional language autonomy, mother-tongue instruction provisions, linguistic minority protections and the Eighth Schedule**, which currently contains **22 languages**.

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Q. Consider the following languages: (2014)

1. Gujarati
2. Kannada
3. Telugu

Which of the above has/have been declared as 'Classical Language/Languages' by the Government?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 3 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (c)

Cardiff Pact and UK Federal Challenge



For Prelims: European Union (EU) , Brexit , Article 1 , Union, State, and Concurrent Lists , Special provisions in Articles 371 to 371-j

For Mains: Comparison between British devolution and Indian federalism, Asymmetric Federalism and Regional Aspirations

Source: TOI

Why in News?

Political leaders from **Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland** signed a **Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) in Cardiff** , calling for constitutional change and asserting the principle of self-determination for their nations.

- The agreement has renewed debate over the **future of the United Kingdom's devolution framework** , as Scotland seeks another independence referendum, Northern Ireland seeks a possible reunification poll, and Wales demands greater constitutional powers.

Summary

- The Cardiff MoU reflects growing tensions within the UK's devolution framework and renewed demands for regional autonomy and self-determination.
- For India, it highlights the importance of asymmetric federalism, fiscal equity, constitutional flexibility, and Centre-State dialogue in balancing regional aspirations with national unity.

What are the Key Highlights of the Cardiff Memorandum of Understanding?

- **Assertion of Self-Determination:** The MoU demands that the British government prepare for, plan, and facilitate constitutional change, stating that "Westminster's time is coming to an end" and that it has no right to block democratic mandates.
- **Pro-European Vision:** A major driver uniting these devolved nations is a shared consensus that their economic and political future belongs within the **European Union (EU)** - a direct rebuttal to the **UK-wide Brexit mandate**.
- **Strategic Cooperation:** Beyond seeking referendums, the pact commits Scotland, Wales, and Northern Ireland to **deepen practical cooperation in areas like the economy and energy resources**.
- **UK Government's (Westminster) Stand:** The UK rejected the pact, declaring referendums "off-limits" and relying on the landmark UK Supreme Court ruling in **Reference by the Lord Advocate (2022)** , which unanimously affirmed parliamentary supremacy by holding that devolved legislatures lack the legal competence to **unilaterally legislate for an independence referendum without**

Westminster's consent.

- Under the 1998 Good Friday Agreement, the UK Secretary of State for Northern Ireland can order a border poll on Irish reunification when evidence indicates majority support for it. The UK Government has maintained that the required threshold for such a poll has not been met.

Historical Background: Formation and Devolution of the UK

- **The Formation (1535-1920):** The UK was forged over centuries. Wales was annexed by **England in the 16th century**.
 - The **Acts of Union in 1707** united the English and Scottish parliaments, while Ireland was brought into the fold in 1801 (and partitioned in 1920, leaving Northern Ireland in the UK).
- **The Devolution Era (Late 1990s):**
 - **Scotland Act (1998):** Granted a Scottish Parliament with significant domestic powers.
 - **Good Friday Agreement (Belfast Agreement) (1998):** Created a power-sharing assembly in Northern Ireland and included a constitutional mechanism for a future "border poll" on Irish unification.
 - **Government of Wales Act (1998):** Established the Welsh Senedd.
- **The Current Friction:** While the late-1990s devolution framework was designed to neutralize regional separatism, Brexit (2020) exposed the structural fragilities of the UK's unitary model through what constitutional scholars term "**constitutional asynchrony**."
 - The English majoritarian mandate unilaterally pulled Scotland (62% Remain) and Northern Ireland (55.8% Remain) out of the European Union, creating a sharp regional democratic deficit.
 - Furthermore, unilateral central measures like the **UK Internal Market Act 2020** were viewed in Scotland and Wales as a "power grab" that overrode devolved regulatory autonomy.
 - Coupled with post-Brexit economic shocks and the outdated **Barnett Formula** (used by the UK Treasury to calculate the annual block grants for the Scottish, Welsh and Northern Irish governments), the devolved nations increasingly perceive Westminster's approach as "**coercive centralism**" rather than collaborative devolution - a sentiment that directly catalyzed the Cardiff MoU.



How does the UK Devolution Framework Compare

to Indian Federalism?

Feature	United Kingdom (Devolved Unitary State)	Republic of India (Quasi-Federal State)
Nature of Polity	Historically a Unitary State ; Westminster retains legal supremacy and can theoretically roll back devolution.	"Union of States" (Article 1) ; a federal structure with a strong unitary bias.
Right to Secede	A voluntary union. The Good Friday Agreement explicitly allows a legal mechanism for Northern Ireland to leave.	"An indestructible Union of destructible states" ; states have no constitutional right to secede (reinforced by the 16 th Constitutional Amendment, 1963).
Asymmetric Federalism	Ad-hoc Devolution: Different regions have varying degrees of power (e.g., Scotland has more autonomy than Wales).	Institutionalized Asymmetry: Special provisions under Articles 371 to 371-J , and the 5th/6th Schedules protect regional uniqueness.
Division of Powers	Unwritten constitution; powers are granted by Acts of the UK Parliament.	A written Constitution clearly divides legislative powers into the Union, State, and Concurrent Lists (7th Schedule) . This federal structure is guarded by the Supreme Court , which acts as the federal umpire and possesses exclusive original jurisdiction to adjudicate disputes between the Centre and the States (Article 131) .

Strategic & Federal Lessons for India

The UK's struggle to maintain unity offers vital administrative and diplomatic takeaways for India:

- **Accommodation Over Coercion:** The UK’s strain demonstrates that persistent denial of regional identity and central overreach (accentuated post-Brexit) can revitalize separatist sentiments. India's

- survival as a vibrant democracy lies in its accommodation of linguistic and cultural diversity through the **States Reorganisation Act (1956)** and regional accords.
- **Effective Utilization of Inter-State Platforms:** A major grievance of the devolved UK governments is Westminster's unilateral decision-making. For India, this highlights the necessity of strengthening institutional consultative forums like the **Inter-State Council (Article 263)** , the **NITI Aayog Governing Council** , and **Zonal Councils** to resolve Centre-State frictions preemptively.
 - **Managing Economic and Fiscal Disparities:** Devolution tensions often stem from perceptions of unfair resource allocation.
 - In India, preserving the neutrality and robustness of the **Finance Commission (Article 280)** is vital to prevent southern or resource-rich states from feeling fiscally marginalized by horizontal devolution formulas.
 - **Asymmetric Federalism: Asymmetry is a stabilizing tool, not a weakness.** India's flexible constitutional mechanisms (e.g., **Article 371 protecting customary laws in the North-East**) provide a viable alternative to hardline centralism, helping align regional identity with national unity.
 - **Preventing Demographic Disenfranchisement:** India's upcoming **delimitation** raises concerns that population-based seat allocation could reduce the political representation of states that successfully controlled population growth.
 - To preserve **federal balance and regional representation** , India may need stronger **Rajya Sabha safeguards, equitable representation mechanisms, and greater Centre-State consultation** by establishing structural safeguards against the **"tyranny of the demographic majority."**
 - **Diplomatic and Strategic Fallout** : A geopolitically weakened UK strengthens the argument for emerging powers like India to assume larger roles in multilateral institutions, including a permanent seat at the **UN Security Council (UNSC)** .

Conclusion

The Cardiff pact highlights the **strain on the UK's asymmetric devolution model** and growing regional demands for self-determination.

For India, it underscores that **national integration is an ongoing process**. Accommodating regional aspirations through **constitutional flexibility, equitable fiscal federalism, and continuous democratic dialogue** remains the most effective **safeguard for an "indestructible Union."**

Drishti Mains Question:

Compare the UK's model of devolution with India's federal structure. What lessons does the UK experience offer for managing regional aspirations in India?

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is the Cardiff Memorandum of Understanding?

The **Cardiff MoU** is a political agreement involving representatives from Scotland, Wales and Northern Ireland seeking **constitutional change and greater self-determination**.

2. What is asymmetric devolution?

Asymmetric devolution provides different regions with varying degrees of legislative and administrative powers, as seen in the UK.

3. What is the significance of Article 263 of the Indian Constitution?

Article 263 provides for an **Inter-State Council** to promote coordination and facilitate discussion between the Centre and States.

4. What is the significance of Article 280?

Article 280 provides for the **Finance Commission**, which recommends the distribution of financial resources between the Union and the States.

5. How does Indian federalism accommodate regional diversity?

India uses **asymmetric provisions, special constitutional arrangements, fiscal transfers and institutional dialogue** to accommodate regional aspirations while maintaining the Union.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/cGAkmKLEePQ](https://www.youtube.com/embed/cGAkmKLEePQ)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs) *Mains*

Q. Compare and contrast the British and Indian approaches to Parliamentary sovereignty. **(2023)**

Q. The judicial systems in India and UK seem to be converging as well as diverging in recent times. Highlight the key points of convergence and divergence between the two nations in terms of their judicial practices. **(2020)**